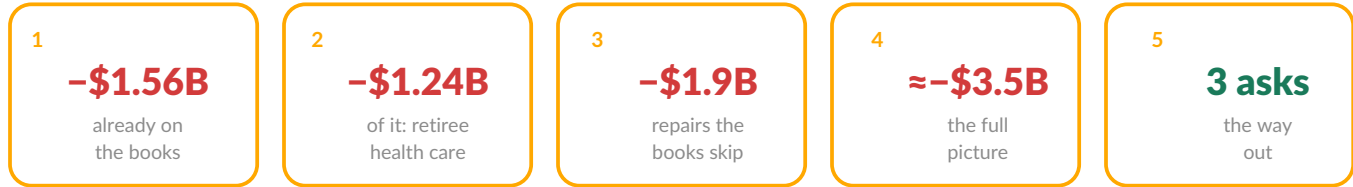


What does Buffalo really owe?

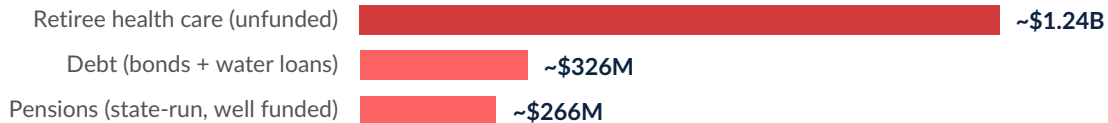
A one-page summary from the city's own audited reports (2006–2025) · buffalofinances.org



The picture, in plain English

Counting only the money it can spend, Buffalo owes about \$1.56 billion more than it holds. That figure comes straight from the city's own audit, and it is mostly health care promised to retirees that was never pre-funded, not borrowing. And one real cost never reaches the books at all: repairing the roads, water mains, and buildings the city already owns. The audit records that about half their value is used up but never totals what fixing them would cost, an estimated \$1.7 to 2.2 billion. Together that is roughly \$3.5 billion, about \$30,000 per household.

Mostly one thing: what the on-the-books gap is made of



Debt and pensions combined are still less than half the retiree-health promise.

THE ASK: ONE NUMBER, ONCE A YEAR

Publish a “cost of good repair” figure every year: what it would take to bring the city's roads, pipes, and buildings back to good condition. A rough first estimate can be built from figures already in the audit. Federal agencies and New York City publish versions of this number, and Buffalo's new data-driven paving program is exactly the right start.

Not a fringe idea: in 2026, a national study by Investortools put this same unmeasured repair burden across ~2,000 U.S. cities at about \$1 trillion, and urged cities to publish it.

It takes one Council member to request it.

Three questions worth asking your Council member

1. After closing this year's gap with a 19% tax increase and added state aid, what is the plan to build the 2027–28 budget on recurring revenue the city controls?
2. What is the plan for the \$1.2 billion retiree-health obligation, on a real, published schedule?
3. Will you request a published “state of good repair” number this year?

Do one thing today: a ready-made, five-minute letter to your Council member is waiting at buffalofinances.org (Take Action). Every figure is checkable there under Data & Sources.